

Effective Communication & Supported Decision-Making

Listen, understand, support expression and respect decisions

Suggested training type: Read + mini quiz Suggested pass mark: 80% Review/validity: 12 months recommended review cycle

Learning objectives

- Recognise communication as a fundamental right.
- Adapt communication to the individual rather than expecting the person to adapt to the worker.
- Support decision-making without taking control.
- Know when communication changes may signal health or safety concerns.

1. Communication partnership

Effective communication is a two-way process. Learn how the person communicates, allow enough time, reduce unnecessary distractions, check understanding, and use the person's preferred methods and communication supports.

2. Practical habits

- Address the person directly rather than speaking only to a family member or support person.
- Use plain language and one idea at a time when helpful.
- Do not pretend to understand - respectfully ask for clarification.
- Use visual, written, gesture, device or other communication methods identified for the person.
- Allow processing time and avoid rushing.
- Confirm important decisions in the way that works best for the person.

3. Supported decision-making

Support the person to understand options, likely outcomes and choices in an accessible way. Avoid steering the decision to what is easiest for the worker. Where formal substitute decision-making arrangements exist, follow the documented authority while still involving the participant as much as possible.

4. Changes in communication

A sudden or unusual change in speech, behaviour, responsiveness, swallowing, cognition or ability to communicate may indicate illness, distress or other risk. Follow the participant's plan and seek appropriate support rather than assuming the person is 'being difficult'.

5. Official module

The NDIS Commission's free Supporting Effective Communication module should be used as an external official learning item. Staff can upload the completion certificate to Opus Care's Training & Compliance Hub.

Knowledge Check

Choose the best answer for each question. Suggested pass mark: 80%. This quiz checks understanding of the module; it does not replace supervised practical competency where that is required.

1. What is effective communication?

- A. Only speaking clearly
- B. A two-way process adapted to the individual
- C. Talking mainly to family
- D. Giving instructions quickly

2. What should a worker do if they do not understand a participant?

- A. Pretend to understand
- B. Ask respectfully for clarification and use known communication supports
- C. Ignore the participant
- D. Guess

3. Supported decision-making means:

- A. Choosing the safest option for the participant every time
- B. Helping the person understand options and make their own decision as far as possible
- C. Making decisions for speed
- D. Asking workers to vote

4. A sudden change in communication should be:

- A. Dismissed as behaviour
- B. Noted and responded to according to health/safety/support procedures
- C. Posted online
- D. Ignored until next month

5. Which official free module is relevant?

- A. Supporting Effective Communication
- B. Tax accounting
- C. Advertising basics
- D. Graphic design

Manager answer key is included in the accompanying quiz JSON file.

Source and reference notes

This Opus Care resource is an original internal training summary. It is based on current public guidance and does not reproduce third-party courses. Workers should use the linked official resources where specified.

- <https://www.ndiscommission.gov.au/online-training-modules>
- <https://www.ndiscommission.gov.au/workforce/supervision-and-effective-communication/working-together-guide-workers>
- <https://www.ndiscommission.gov.au/rules-and-standards/rights-people-disability>

Important: Internal completion does not create a nationally recognised qualification, professional licence, or practical competency. Opus Care should verify external qualifications and practical skills appropriate to each worker's role and the supports actually delivered.